

soldier—and was briefly imprisoned for taking part in the Commune (an uprising in Paris). Claude's early musical education came from an aunt, who sent him for piano lessons with a woman who claimed to have been taught by Frédéric Chopin.

Claude made rapid progress and, at the age of 10, was accepted at the Paris Conservatoire. It soon became clear that he would not make the grade as a virtuoso pianist, but he performed well enough to win the Prix de Rome in 1884, which entitled him to three years' study in Italy. Before this, Claude enjoyed summer jobs working for Nadezhda von Meck, the wealthy benefactor of Tchaikovsky. She took him traveling and introduced him to Russian music, most notably Borodin and Rimsky-Korsakov.

## A rebellious streak

Debussy found many of the professors at the Conservatoire too traditional, and balked at following orthodox methods of composition, noting: "I don't think I shall ever be able to put music into a strict mold." His studies in Italy proved equally depressing. He disliked the Villa Medici and his fellow students and was bored by Rome. After two years, he returned to Paris.